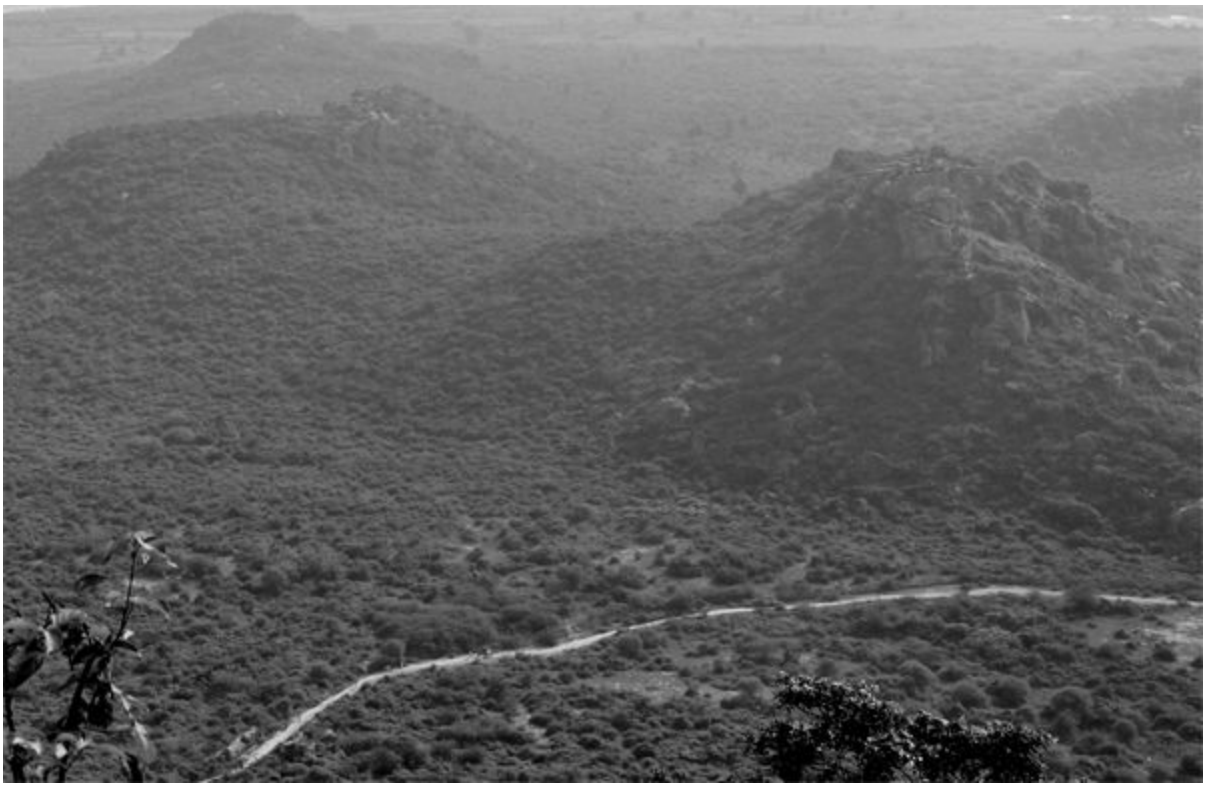


Fig. 10.1: Hills around the Barabar caves, the Phalgu river in the background

In 257/256 BCE, the year that Ashoka issued his rescripts about the merit of proper courtesy and proper behaviour towards ‘Shramanas and Brahmanas’—subsequently these appeared in the Third and Fourth Major Rock Edicts—he had caves excavated, these being incarnations, in a way, of his beliefs. Tolerance for all sects, the honouring of elders in all religious communities, and the desire that religious sects live across his dominions were thus supervised and ensured as material events. Appropriately, the four Barabar caves were not exclusively for Buddhists. One of them may have been Buddhist; at least two were given to the Ajivikas in the twelfth year after his coronation.

Barabar is the name of the highest hill among the rocky ridges that presently lie in the Jahanabad district of Bihar, some twenty-four km north of Gaya, and therefore only a day’s journey from Pataliputra. A large part of the area around the hill, like the environs surrounding Pataliputra,